

Patients, Partnerships and Progress:

SPARC's Latest Developments

As we approach the summer period, SPARC continues to make significant progress across its scientific, clinical, patient engagement, and governance activities. Over the past months, several important milestones have been achieved, reflecting the collaborative efforts of the consortium and its commitment to advancing personalised cancer medicine across Europe.

This edition of the newsletter highlights three key developments: the successful launch of the SPARC Patient and Caregiver Advisory Group (PCAG), SPARC's participation in the International Society of Liquid Biopsy (ISLB) meeting in Pompei, and the establishment of the project's Scientific Advisory Board. Together, these milestones demonstrate SPARC's commitment to combining scientific excellence, patient involvement, and strategic guidance to support the implementation of personalised cancer care.



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Putting Patients and Caregivers at the Centre of SPARC: The PCAG Is Now Underway



On May 21st, 2026, SPARC officially launched its **Patient and Caregiver Advisory Group (PCAG)** with a highly successful kick-off meeting that exceeded expectations in terms of participation and engagement.

The PCAG was established to ensure that patient and caregiver perspectives are integrated throughout the project and actively contribute to the development of more equitable, accessible, and patient-centred approaches to personalised cancer medicine.

We are excited to announce that the group already brings **together 37 members** from different countries, backgrounds, and cancer communities, creating a diverse and motivated network of individuals willing to contribute their experience and expertise to the project.

During the kick-off meeting, participants were introduced to both SPARC and the **Joint Action on Personalised Cancer Medicine (JA PCM)**, while also discussing the objectives, responsibilities, and expected contribution of the PCAG.

The group will support SPARC by:

- ✓ Bringing patient and caregiver voices into project activities and decision-making processes;
- ✓ Ensuring that personalised cancer care reflects real patient needs and experiences;
- ✓ Representing perspectives across the seven cancer areas addressed by SPARC;
- ✓ Contributing to patient engagement activities, educational materials, and guidelines;
- ✓ Helping improve the clarity and accessibility of project communications and study information.

One particularly inspiring moment of the meeting was the discussion around participants' motivations for joining the group. The responses highlighted a shared commitment to advocacy, collaboration, research, and improving outcomes for future patients.

Liquid Biopsy, SPARC and the Next Step for Personalised Cancer Medicine



SPARC was also represented at the **International Society of Liquid Biopsy (ISLB)** Meeting, held in Pompei, Italy, on 22–23 May 2026.

The event brought together experts from research, clinical practice, policy, and healthcare implementation to discuss one of the most rapidly evolving areas of personalised oncology: liquid biopsy.

Across presentations and discussions, a common message emerged clearly: the scientific potential of liquid biopsy is increasingly recognised, but the real challenge now lies in implementation. Questions surrounding standardisation, quality assurance, reimbursement, workforce readiness, clinical integration, and equitable access remain central to ensuring that these technologies reach patients effectively.

This discussion aligns closely with SPARC's objectives.

Through its work on next-generation sequencing (NGS), liquid biopsy protocols, Molecular Tumour Boards, training programmes, patient engagement, and policy recommendations, SPARC seeks to address many of the barriers that currently limit the widespread adoption of personalised cancer medicine.

Representatives from the SPARC consortium participated actively in discussions throughout the event, including **Manuel Ottaviano, Umberto Malapelle, Eloisa Jantus, Paul Hoffman, and Denis Horgan**.

Content Coming Soon

The SPARC communication team (WP9) was present throughout the meeting and recorded a series of interviews and video content featuring participants and experts attending the event. Stay tuned for interviews, expert perspectives, and key insights.

SPARC Establishes its Scientific Advisory Board

Another important milestone achieved during this reporting period is the formal establishment of the SPARC Scientific Advisory Board.

The Board has been created to provide independent scientific expertise, strategic guidance, and critical assessment throughout the lifetime of the project. Its role is to challenge assumptions, identify potential risks and opportunities, and support the consortium in ensuring that project outputs remain scientifically robust, clinically relevant, and aligned with real-world implementation needs.

The first meeting of the Scientific Advisory Board recently took place, bringing together experts from multiple disciplines and sectors.

During the meeting, SPARC Project Coordinator Manuel Ottaviano and Scientific Board Chair Mario Pazzagli presented the project's vision, objectives, and current activities. This was followed by a constructive exchange of ideas, questions, reflections, and recommendations from Board members. Particularly valuable was the focus on implementation: discussions addressed not only innovation and scientific opportunity, but also practical challenges, healthcare system realities, and the need to ensure that project outcomes can ultimately benefit patients in real clinical settings.

Members of the Scientific Advisory Board

Mario Pazzagli

Professor of Clinical Biochemistry and Molecular Biology

Professor at the University of Florence and internationally recognised expert in molecular diagnostics, biomarker standardisation, and pre-analytical quality.

Role within the Board: Chair of the Scientific Advisory Board, providing strategic guidance on diagnostic quality, molecular testing workflows, and methodological robustness across SPARC activities.

Mario Plebani

Professor of Clinical Biochemistry

Director of the Department of Laboratory Medicine at the University Hospital of Padova and globally recognised authority in laboratory quality and diagnostic innovation.

Role within the Board: Supporting the scientific robustness of diagnostic activities and advising on laboratory-related aspects of SPARC's clinical pilots.

José M. Martín-Moreno

Professor of Preventive Medicine and Public Health

Professor at the University of Valencia and senior adviser to the European Observatory on Health Systems and Policies.

Role within the Board: Bringing a public health and policy perspective to ensure alignment with European cancer control strategies and healthcare system priorities.

Ishtar Espejo

Executive Director, Fundación Aladina

Member of the Regional Advisory Committee of the St. Jude Global Euro Regional Program and leading advocate for children and adolescents affected by cancer.

Role within the Board: Ensuring that patient-centred perspectives, psychosocial considerations, and equity remain central to SPARC activities.

Nadia Harbeck

Director of the Breast Center, LMU University Hospital

Internationally recognised expert in personalised breast cancer treatment, early detection, and multidisciplinary oncology care.

Role within the Board: Advising on the clinical relevance of project findings and supporting the translation of scientific evidence into practical recommendations for patient care.



Looking Ahead

While the first half of the year has already marked several important milestones for SPARC, the months ahead promise to be equally active, with new opportunities to strengthen collaboration, increase visibility, and further advance the project's objectives.

1 One of the major upcoming events will be the annual ESMO Congress 2026, taking place this year in Madrid. SPARC will be represented at the congress through the active participation of consortium partners, while the European Alliance for Personalised Medicine, leading SPARC's Communication, Dissemination and Policy Work Package (WP9), will organise a in-person side event where the project and its contribution to advancing personalised cancer medicine across Europe will be prominently featured.

2 Another important milestone planned for the second half of the year is the publication of the first joint SPARC-JA PCM newsletter. Developed collaboratively as part of the communication and synergy plan between the two initiatives, this publication represents one of the annual joint deliverables agreed within the SPARC-JA PCM collaboration framework. The newsletter will showcase shared activities, highlight complementary achievements, and demonstrate how both projects are working together to accelerate the implementation of personalised cancer medicine across Europe.

3 Alongside these initiatives, SPARC will continue to publish new interviews, news articles, event updates, and communication materials across its website and social media channels, ensuring that stakeholders remain informed about the project's progress and the results emerging from its scientific, clinical, patient engagement, and policy activities.

We look forward to sharing these developments with you after the summer break and to continuing this collaborative journey towards more equitable, innovative, and patient-centred cancer care across Europe. **See you after the summer break for more SPARC updates!**





Universidad Politécnica de Madrid

The Universidad Politécnica de Madrid (UPM) coordinates the SPARC Project. Building on its extensive research experience in personalized cancer medicine, UPM sees SPARC as a unique opportunity to bridge the gap between scientific and technological innovation and real-world clinical practice.

Despite significant and transformative advances in oncology, the adoption of PCM remains uneven across cancer types, healthcare institutions, and European regions. Persistent challenges related to sustainability, interoperability, accessibility, and equity continue to limit the full potential of personalized approaches in cancer care.

SPARC provides a unique framework to comprehensively assess the European landscape of PCM implementation, identify existing barriers and disparities, and develop evidence-based strategies to address heterogeneity in healthcare practices and reduce inequalities in access to innovative cancer diagnostics and treatments.

As project coordinator, UPM will play a central role in fostering collaboration and synergies with key European initiatives, including the Joint Action on Personalized Medicine (JA PM). In addition, UPM will contribute to the development of a portfolio of technologies, best practices, and implementation frameworks designed to support the effective and sustainable deployment of Precision Cancer Medicine across Europe.



Vall d'Hebron Institute of Oncology

VHIO has extensive experience implementing precision medicine in clinical practice and contributing to European initiatives focused on personalised cancer medicine, including Basket of Baskets within Cancer Core Europe, CGI-Clinics, and the Joint Action on Personalised Cancer Medicine (JA PCM). Within JA PCM, we lead the pilot on implementing a supranational Molecular Tumor Board (MTB), participate in the liquid biopsy pilot assessing ctDNA-based MRD to guide adjuvant treatment decisions in colorectal cancer, and contribute to developing a European personalised cancer medicine treatment network and advanced training programmes for healthcare professionals.

Within SPARC, VHIO contributes this expertise and its links with ongoing European initiatives in precision oncology. We lead the Synergy Working Group on MTBs, promoting alignment between SPARC and JA PCM, and the twinning activities to build synergies and capacities across centres, in close connection with our role in JA PCM and JA EUnetCCC, where we contribute to establishing a precision cancer diagnostics network for learning and exchange.

VHIO also contributes to SPARC tasks related to digital tools, patient engagement, inequalities and sustainability in personalised cancer medicine, supporting implementation through multidisciplinary collaboration, strengthened institutional capacities and harmonised approaches to molecular diagnostics and treatment decision-making.

VHIO believes that SPARC's mission is essential to make precision oncology more accessible, equitable and sustainable across Europe. By connecting clinical expertise, molecular diagnostics, digital innovation and collaborative networks, SPARC provides an opportunity to reduce fragmentation, accelerate learning between centres and bring high-quality personalised cancer medicine closer to patients.



NACIONALNO
DRUŠTVO BOLNIKOV
Z MELANOMOM

The National Melanoma Society

The National Melanoma Society (NMS) from Slovenia is a patient organization dedicated to supporting patients and their loved ones and advocating on their behalf. NMS serves as a bridge between oncologists, clinicians, researchers, and patients, empowering patient representatives to fulfil this role professionally and effectively. NMS joined SPARC to deepen its understanding of personalised cancer medicine (PCM), exchange experience with partners, and translate the project's findings into national practice. NMS also represents patients on the SPARC–JA PCM Synergy Board, contributing the patient perspective to the alignment of both initiatives.

The Slovenian SPARC team is primarily engaged in patient engagement and empowerment, and in supporting the sustainability and accessibility of PCM. In WP7, NMS participates in the Patient and Caregivers Advisory Group (PCAG) and leads co-creation sessions involving clinicians, researchers, and patient representatives. This work helps patient representatives understand and explain the value of advanced diagnostics, including liquid biopsy (LB) and next-generation sequencing (NGS), and the role of molecular tumor boards (MTBs), while engaging patients and caregivers in the project's clinical pilots.

NMS also contributes to training materials, patient empowerment activities, and communication and dissemination of SPARC's results. In WP8, Slovenian experts are conducting a comparative analysis of PCM implementation across European healthcare systems to identify best practices and develop recommendations for effective integration. NMS also contributes to tasks related to digital tools supporting PCM.

SPARC is advancing the implementation of PCM across European healthcare systems by promoting standardized approaches to advanced diagnostics, therapy decision-making in MTBs, and education for their implementation. From a patient's perspective, the project places strong emphasis on the engagement and empowerment of patient organizations—an essential element of more patient-centred cancer care and a core part of NMS's mission. NMS is proud to contribute to SPARC and looks forward to supporting its impact at both the European and national levels.

